



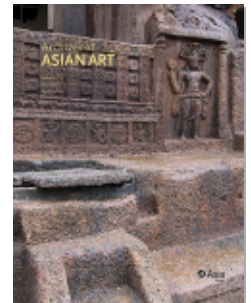
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Buddhist Rainmaking Rituals in Early South Asia

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Snakes and Gutters

Nāga Imagery, Water Management, and Buddhist Rainmaking Rituals in Early South Asia

ROBERT DECAROLI

ABSTRACT Visitors to early (second century BCE–fifth century CE) Buddhist monastic sites across South Asia encountered prominent figural images of *nāgas*, serpent-like beings who were believed to be closely connected to water and rainfall. Such images are commonly identified as guardians and occasionally have been linked to nearby water systems, such as ponds, tanks, and rivers. Yet, these images have not been studied as an aspect of water regulation within the monasteries themselves. This paper will first consider the water-related challenges that confronted the monks and architects at rock-cut monasteries. Then methods of hydraulic engineering designed to regulate the flow of water at the sites will be considered in relation to the role of *nāga* imagery. Their proximity to gutters and tanks reveals the Buddhist reliance on supernatural forces as an aspect of water control. The highly visible nature of this arrangement helps to explain the emergence of ritual texts, primarily after the fourth century CE, in which Buddhist ritualists adopt the role of rainmakers. These elaborate ceremonies promise to bring rain or end flooding for the benefit of the *saṃgha* and the wider community. The ritualists invariably invoke a special relationship with the *nāgas*, whom they enjoin to rectify undesirable conditions. This connection between image and text reveals a centuries-long process by which the monastic community developed an association with weather regulation that was contingent on a cultivated and highly public relationship with Buddhist-friendly *nāgas*.

KEYWORDS *Nāga*, Buddhist architecture, rock-cut architecture, water regulation, rain-making rituals

In 1868, as part of the Meiji-era reforms aimed at dividing Shinto practices from those of Buddhism, the Japanese government legally separated a cave shrine housing a Dragon King from the nearby monastery of Murō-ji. The nineteenth-century officials apparently did not recognize the cave shrine as being intrinsically linked to the monastery or its practices, even though there are clear records of the Buddhist monastic community of Murō-ji performing yearly rainmaking rituals to the Dragon King as early as the eighth century and continuing into the seventeenth.¹ Despite this historical information, it is not difficult to understand the position taken by the Meiji officials, because even now those familiar with the history of Buddhism do not often associate it with weather control.

Ritual texts, which elucidate the details of monastic weather regulation, are among the least-studied bodies of Buddhist literature. The fact remains, however, that for many centuries such practices were highly visible and widely spread across the Buddhist world. By the fifth century the South Asian Buddhist community had already developed several rites (*varṣāpaṇavidhi*, or rainmaking rituals) instructing ritual specialists on how to regulate rainfall.

For example, the *Vajratuṇḍasamayakalparāja*, which has been discussed by Gergley Hidas,² promises to create favorable weather for those who follow its guidance. The text dates to the Gupta dynasty, placing it somewhere between the fourth and sixth centuries. Divided into six chapters, it includes several narrative

testimonials to the ritual's effectiveness, a variety of *dhāraṇīs* (short magical formulas), descriptions of the ritual's benefits, and lengthy instructions on how the ritual is to be performed. A similar body of materials can be found in the *Mahāmegha-sūtra*, which was translated into Chinese in the ninth century but likely originated in South Asia during the early fifth.³ In it the reader is promised a variety of benefits, some of which derive from brief *dhāraṇīs* and others that involve complex ceremonies intended to end either drought or deluge. Another point of commonality uniting these works is that neither claims to be effective through the direct power of the ritualist (*vidyādhara*); rather, the weather is altered indirectly by *nāgas* (often translated as “dragons” in East Asia), serpent-like deities associated with water who act as intermediaries for the ritual expert.

These rituals utilize a variety of techniques to convince the *nāgas* to alter the local weather patterns. Often the harsh conditions that justify the need for the ritual—typically drought or flood—are assumed to have been caused by the negligence or maliciousness of these ophidian deities. Thus the component actions of the rituals are designed primarily to convince the *nāgas* to help, and use a variety of techniques to do so. Typically, there is an appeal to the *nāgas*' sense of Buddhist morality and compassion by asking them to take pity on those who are suffering. In other instances, the rituals point out the karmic benefits of kindness or ask the *nāgas* to recall ancient oaths. Occasionally, they are more coercive, resorting to threats if the ritualist's goals are not met—the implication being that by ignoring Buddhist teachings and allowing the weather to harm others, the *nāgas* expose themselves to danger and karmic retribution. Conversely, rewards are promised for generous behavior.

One example is the *Mahāmegha-sutra*, which states that a multitude of *nāgas* (described as a *samudra*, or “ocean”) attended the Buddha as he preached a sermon in response to a question posed by the king of the *nāgas*. The *nāga* king asked how the *nāgas*' troubles might subside and whether, in their joy, they might bring forth seasonable rain to the world. The Buddha commends the question and responds by directing the *nāgas* to follow the law of charity, which reduces the suffering of all beings. Should the *nāgas* forget or fail to live up to these standards, the ritual serves as a reminder of this lesson.⁴

The *Mūlyamantradhāraṇī-sūtra*, tentatively dated to the early sixth century by Ronald M. Davidson,

reveals similar characteristics. It is a complete ritual manual for rainmaking that employs a Buddhist framework to direct the regional *nāga* or *nāgas* to produce rainfall. It does so with a full set of ritual instructions, explicating how to construct the altar, how to make and decorate the image of the *nāga*, what mantras to recite, and what contingencies are available if complications arise.⁵

Promises of proper rainfall appear with great regularity throughout the Buddhist *dhāraṇī* literature. Even texts that are not primarily concerned with the weather often include brief passages that provide assurances of agreeable *nāgas* and bountiful seasonal rains. For example, the *Mahāmāyūri Vidyārājñī*, which mainly protects against snakebites and a variety of other dangers, enjoins its readers to recite the charm in times of drought or flood. The text promises that it will make the *nāgas* zealous to end drought or remove floodwaters.⁶ The *Mahāpratisarā Mahāvīdyārājñī* offers similar assurances. It claims, among a long list of other benefits, that the great *nāgas* of the region will be persuaded to send rain showers at the proper times and all manner of unwelcome weather can be abated.⁷

Perhaps because these ritual texts seem to depart from general, modern expectations about Buddhist practices, they are often overlooked. Much as the Meiji-era officials identified rainmaking practices as non-Buddhist, one might be tempted to dismiss these rites as marginal, or to view them as exceptional outliers in the history of South Asian Buddhism. In this paper, I suggest the opposite. I hope to demonstrate that these rites are the natural culmination of a process of association between *nāgas*, water control, and the monastic community that began long before they were first composed. To see this connection, however, it is necessary to look beyond the textual sources and consider the history of Buddhist material culture and monastery construction.

For the early Buddhist community in South Asia there were several challenges associated with choosing a location at which to build a monastery. It was both traditional and preferable that the site be suitable for meditative practices and away from the noise of the city. Yet the setting could not be overly remote, because the residents of the monastery depended on the alms offered by the urban lay population. Without this dependable source of food and clothing the monastic institution would not have been able to function. Other concerns had to be considered as well. For example, monasteries had to be far enough from any

city to be quiet and restful, but sufficiently close so that an alarm sounded by the monks would be heard and draw a response. Even the monasteries' aesthetic qualities could be a factor in attracting visitors from nearby population centers.⁸ This leaves a rather narrow range of sites that would provide the appropriate levels of proximity and distance to meet the spiritual and practical needs of the monastic community.

Archaeological evidence suggests that in actuality these ideal criteria were difficult to meet, especially for those desiring a rock-cut dwelling, which could be excavated only on suitable mountainsides. Such cave-like monasteries were built primarily between the second century BCE and the fifth century CE and are among the best-preserved examples of early Buddhist architecture. Rock-cut monasteries can be found across most parts of South Asia, and many spectacular examples are located in the Western Ghats (a mountain range that runs along the western coast of the subcontinent) and inland along the various river valleys that carve up the Deccan plateau. They range in size from the very modest (such as Kondivte) to the grandiose (such as Ajanta), and only some of them are associated with nearby urban centers. We assume that the rest were supported by their proximity to well-traveled trade routes. Yet given that the placement of these monasteries posed profound logistical challenges and the work was extremely labor-intensive, why were donors, monks, and craftspeople willing to go to such extraordinary lengths to construct them?

Despite the challenges faced by communities living in these mountainous places, there were of course some distinct advantages. Donations to the Buddhist order were believed to bear karmic results as long as the caves continued to be used. Therefore, the unparalleled permanency of stone construction assured the donors nearly perpetual karmic rewards over many lifetimes.⁹

Another benefit of these locations, one that is often overlooked, is access to water. India, like most of southern Asia, has a distinct dry season that alternates with a rainy season associated with the arrival of annual monsoons. This feast-or-famine availability of water can have a dramatic impact on the environment and radically alters the landscape of the region over the course of months. Adding to this seasonal contrast are the waterfalls that flow in great torrents during periods of rain. Many well-known monasteries—Ajanta, Ellora, Bhaja, Karle, Kondane, and Kanheri, among others—are situated adjacent to seasonal



Figure 1. Waterfall at the Kondane Caves, India, 2014.
Photograph: Robert DeCaroli.

waterfalls (Figure 1). The presence of cascades and rivers is not unexpected, given that water erosion created most of these cliffs in the first place, but the number of monasteries located near scenic waterfalls suggests that the builders had a preference for beautiful vistas of this type.

Although being proximate to a cascading water source might be dramatic, it is useful for quenching the thirst of monks only when the rain is falling and the seasonal rivers flow. For this reason, all of these monasteries also relied on elaborately engineered systems of gutters and cisterns that ensured a year-round supply of water. Some are quite modest in scale, whereas others are massive, subterranean spaces (Figure 2). It



Figure 2. Cisterns outside Cave 2 at Kanheri, west of Mumbai, India, second century CE. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2014.



is difficult to generalize about what is typical for these cisterns, however, because for several reasons most have never been measured. Openings were often kept small to prevent evaporation, so what is visible on the exterior rarely gives an indication of what lies beneath. Moreover, measuring these cavities would require both climbing shoes and diving gear (Figure 3). Nevertheless, a simple visual survey of them reveals a wide variety of sizes and shapes. While they may lack the accessibility and ornamentation of monastic dwellings and ritual spaces, we must keep in mind that these excavated spaces were major architectural undertakings and vital components of life on these mountainsides. A good example is the Buddhist cave site of Kanheri.

Composed of more than one hundred individual caves in the hills above Mumbai, Kanheri was built over a long span of time, with the bulk of the construction concentrated in the second and third centuries. The community drew its support from the urban population on the coast, and its beautiful setting, commanding views, and carefully engineered ornamental waterways still draw visitors today (Figure 4). The path of the water flow was carefully orchestrated, at times gentle and at times torrential. Channels and gutters collect the water flowing above the caves and direct it either away from the monastery or into cisterns located near the entrances of most caves (Figure 5). Those gutters that lead away from the caves served as drainage channels. Those that redirected the water toward the caves ensured that a sufficient amount of the rainwater was captured for use throughout the year (Figure 6).

Although much is understood about the creation of the cisterns, dams, and gutters that directed and stored water, this is only half of the engineering problem that the ancient builders faced. The other half involved ongoing maintenance and upkeep, which often centered on managing the erosion and invasive water damage that could, over time, destroy the caves and cause dangerous mountain slides. Consider again the

Figure 3. Water tank at Shivneri Caves, Junnar, India, first century CE. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2014.



Figure 4. Watercourse through Kanheri Caves, west of Mumbai, India, second–third century CE. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2014.



Figure 5. Water collection channel and cistern in the doorway of Kanheri Cave 77, west of Mumbai, India, second–third century CE. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2014.



Figure 6. Water collection channel and cistern in the doorway of Kanheri Cave 59 in the rain, west of Mumbai, India, second–third century CE. The outer edge of the channel has eroded. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2014.

placement of gutters at Kanheri (Figure 7). Although they serve to collect water, they also protect the entryway to the caves by channeling the water away from the entrance. This assuredly makes it more pleasant for those entering and exiting (who avoid getting water dumped on their heads), but it also prevents erosion of the thin stone and sculptural decorations placed on the cave's exterior.

To appreciate how damaging water can be, consider the collapsed exteriors of Bhaja and Pitalkhora (Figure 8). Both sites were badly damaged when their respective cliff faces collapsed, taking with them the exterior portions of the monastic dwellings. Even the interiors of rock-cut structures were at risk if moisture seeped into the caves. For example, Junnar's Amba-Ambika chaitya was abandoned before its completion (Figures 9 and 10). The builders were correct to do so, because water damage had weakened the interior by eroding a vein of softer stone running diagonally through the walls. Similar problems afflicted Junnar 18 and 19 in the Lenyadri group. Any fissures or breaks in the stone were quickly exacerbated by the action of the water, and, if unaddressed, could become serious problems. In Cave 66 at Kanheri we can see where erosion followed a diagonal split in the stone, but in that case interior channels were added to the walls in an effort to redirect the water (Figure 11). This might have worked for a time, but ultimately it proved to be ineffective. The preventative measures at Cave 75 at Kan-



Figure 7. Gutter above Kanheri Cave 5, west of Mumbai, India, second century CE. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2014.



Figure 8. Pitalkhora Caves exterior, Western Ghats, India, second century BCE–third century CE. The remaining architectural elements indicate the original size of the façade. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 1997.



Figure 10. Interior of the Amba-Ambika Chaitya (Cave 26), Junnar, India, first century CE. Note the diagonal band of soft rock exacerbated by erosion. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2014.



Figure 9. Unfinished interior of Amba-Ambika Chaitya (Cave 26), Junnar, India, first century CE. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2014.



Figure 11. Interior of Kanheri Cave 66, west of Mumbai, India, second–third century CE. The channel was added to mitigate water damage. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2014.

heri were more extensive and more effective in protecting the integrity of the cave (Figures 12 and 13). The channel cut into the wall catches the water and directs it to gutters in the floor, which lead out of the cave (Figures 14 and 15).

Perhaps the most successful attempt at circumventing water damage, however, can be seen at Bedsa (Figure 16). The presence of what appears to be a monastic cell attached to the chaitya hall is an exceptionally unusual feature, with no parallel example in



Figure 12. Water damage from the interior of Kanheri Cave 75, west of Mumbai, India, second–third century CE. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2014.



Figure 13. Interior of Kanheri Cave 75, west of Mumbai, India, second–third century CE. The channel was added to redirect damaging water seepage. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2014.



Figure 14. Interior of Kanheri Cave 75, west of Mumbai, India, second–third century CE. The gutter redirects water out of the cave. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2014.



Figure 15. Exterior of Kanheri Cave 75, west of Mumbai, India, second–third century CE. Note the water drainage spout in the lower left. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2014.

any other South Asian monastic plan (Figure 17).¹⁰ This arrangement is quite puzzling until we realize that the room is not a residence, but rather was added to redirect water before it could reach and destroy the main hall. Seepage can still be seen during the rainy season. There is a channel connecting this cell to one that exits onto the verandah, providing a way for the water to escape harmlessly (Figure 18). The well-preserved condition of the hall verifies that this intervention ful-

filled (and continues to fulfill) its function exceptionally well.

The architects and donors of these caves grappled with the regulation of water, which meant planning for times of scarcity as well as for overabundance. As we have seen, they developed a number of complex techniques and solutions for addressing those needs. Yet for the ancient builders and residents of these mountainside dwellings, engineering feats were only part of



Figure 16. Interior of Bedse Chaitya (Cave 1), Western Ghats, India, first century BCE. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2014.



Figure 17. View of cell attached to the Bedse Chaitya (Cave 1), Western Ghats, India, first century BCE. Note the water seepage. Photograph: Shrikant Ganvir, 2017.

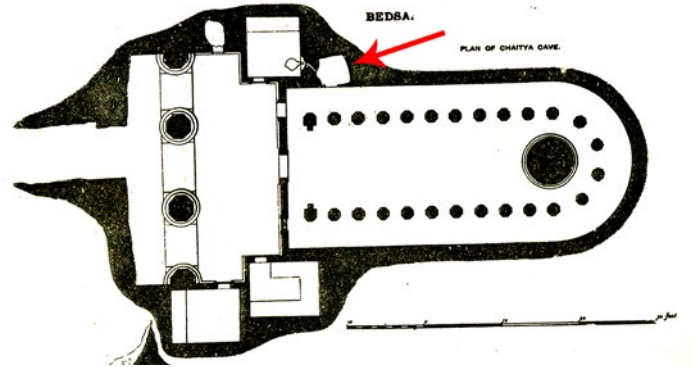


Figure 18. Plan of the Bedse Chaitya, first century BCE. Note the channel connecting the interior cell to the cell on the verandah. From James Burgess, *Report on the Buddhist Cave Temples and Their Inscriptions* (Delhi: Trübner, 1876–79), pl. XI.

the solution. Equally important, and typically much more visible to the casual visitor, were their religious solutions to these problems.

The regulation of water was seen to be a concern not just for architects and craftspeople but also for monks and ritual experts. The decoration of the early Buddhist monasteries, which often feature depictions of deities associated with water and rainfall, readily reveal this approach to problem solving. Such figures are more than just decorative and are best understood as active presences with the capacity to impact monastic life. Among the most frequently encountered of these deities are *nāgas*, depicted either as multiheaded serpents or as shapely humans with an array of multiple cobra hoods emerging from behind their head.

At Kanheri Cave 3 an image of a *nāga* was placed directly above the water cistern (Figure 19). This association is more than just a coincidence. Julia Shaw has noted the common placement of *nāgas* along irrigation channels and waterways across portions of central India.¹¹ This association is reinforced by a passage in the *Kṣudrakavastu* of the *Mūlasarvāstivāda Vinaya* in which the Buddha instructs a wealthy donor on the decoration of his monastery. In this passage he states that in the water hall one should depict a *nāga* holding a flask in its hands and adorned with ornaments.¹² It is not clear how universally this rule was put into practice, but early inscriptions, both Buddhist and non-Buddhist, make it apparent that *nāgas* were linked with water tanks and cisterns over much of South Asia, pointing to the widespread and long-lasting acceptance of this connection.

For example, two second-century inscriptions from the Mathura region reveal that water tanks were



Figure 19. *Nāga* and cistern, exterior of Kanheri Cave 3, west of Mumbai, India, second century CE. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2014.

donated to *nāgas* and that their cult images were at times enshrined at such locations. The Ral Bhadar inscription records the donation of a tank and garden for the *nāga* Bhūmo, who is presumably depicted on the accompanying sculpture (Figure 20).¹³ The second Mathura inscription, this one from Chargaon, is also found on a sculpture. It states that two donors commissioned a tank and image in honor of a *nāga* who is not named in the inscription (Figure 21).¹⁴ Far south of Mathura, in what is now the state of Karnataka, the Banavasi inscription records the donation of a *nāga* and water tank by a princess in the third century.¹⁵ A tank was also established at Kala Darah in the Swat valley in modern Pakistan with similar intentions. In that example, the donor states that he dedicates the tank for the worship of all *nāgas*.¹⁶

This is similar to practices found in Sri Lanka, where *nāgas* are frequently associated with monastic water tanks. A good example can be seen in the site of

Mihintale, where a tank known as the Naga Pokuna is accompanied by a massive, albeit heavily damaged, sculpture of a five-hooded *nāga* who appears to rise from the pool's water (Figure 22). Although there is textual evidence that the pool existed in earlier periods, the sculpture and current tank date to the sixth or seventh century.¹⁷ One might try to make the case that such sculptural elements are merely decorative, but this claim is countered by a group of bronze objects depicting aquatic creatures, including a multiheaded *nāga*, that were excavated from the bottom of a water tank in the Jetavana monastery located in Anuradhapura (Figure 23). The bronzes were all placed in a sealed stone casket that was deposited at the bottom of the tank. The fact that these objects were hidden eliminates the possibility that they were decorative. This sealed collection was almost certainly part of a ritual deposit, presumably intended to assure the abundance of the tank's waters. It exhibits similarities to the

Sri Lankan custom of placing stone containers, called *yantragalas*, under religious sculpture and architecture (Figure 24). Typically divided into a grid of nine or twenty-five cells, these containers often hold sacred and auspicious objects intended to protect and empower whatever is built above them.¹⁸ A second sealed ritual deposit with bronze images of aquatic creatures was located under the Kutta Pokuna (Twin Ponds) at Abhayagiri. Although no *nāga* image was found among the bronzes, there is a prominent *nāga* image at the tank (Figure 25). The water flows into the first, smaller pool through a spout located below a five-headed *nāga*, the only sculptural ornament at the site.¹⁹ Both the tank and the sculpture date to the sixth century.



Figure 20. *Nāga* (Bhūmo?) and *nāgīs* from Ral Bhadar, second century CE (Kaniṣka year 8). Government Museum Mathura, Mathura, India. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 1997.

One of the clearest examples of the association between *nāgas* and Buddhist water management is also one of the oldest (second or third century BCE). It is found at the western site of Pitalkhora. Although the entire outer portion of the rock-cut monastery collapsed centuries ago, a portion of the outer gateway remains (see Figure 8). The doorway itself is



Figure 21. *Nāga* from Chargaon, second century CE (Huvīṣka year 40). Government Museum Mathura, Mathura, India. Photograph: American Institute of Indian Studies (AIIS).



Figure 22. Five-headed *nāga* rising from Naga Pokuna, Mihitale, Sri Lanka, late sixth century CE. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2016.



Figure 24. Example of a *yantragala*, fourth–sixth century CE. Jetavana Museum, Anuradhapura, Sri Lanka. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2016.



Figure 23. Bronze *nāga* from cache of objects deposited below the Jetavana monastery water tank, Anuradhapura, Sri Lanka, sixth century CE. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2016.



Figure 25. *Nāga* image and waterspout in Kuttam Pokuna, Anuradhapura, Sri Lanka, sixth century CE. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 2016.

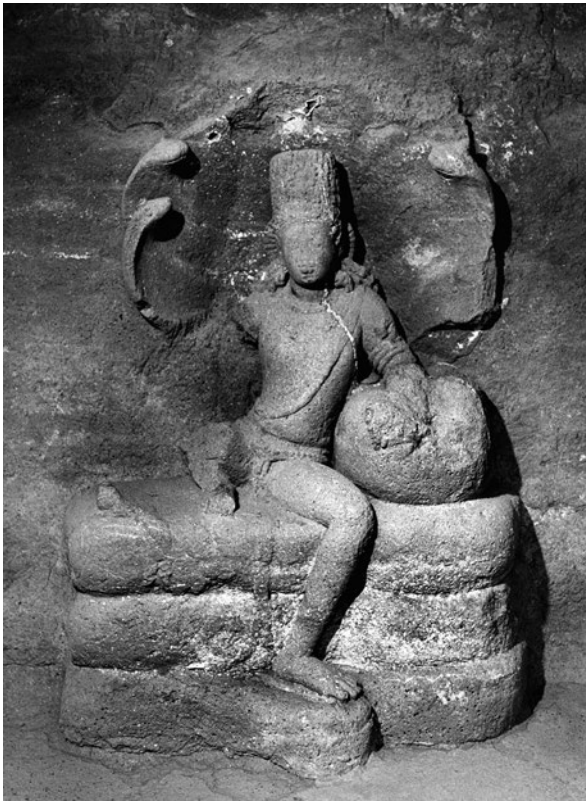
flanked by powerful guardian figures standing next to a row of elephants; off to one side is a partially eroded relief sculpture depicting a *nāga* in the form of a multi-headed cobra (Figure 26). Closer examination reveals that it is placed directly in front of a gutter that collected runoff water from farther up the mountain. In the rainy season water would have run through this



Figure 26. Multi-headed *nāga* with a water spout in each mouth, entryway to the Pitalkhora Caves, Western Ghats, India, second century BCE–third century CE. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 1997.



Figure 27. View of Ajanta Caves, Aurangabad District, India, second century BCE–fifth century CE. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 1997.



narrow channel (accessible via openings carved into the stairway) and pass (or spray) through holes carved into the *nāga*'s multiple mouths and into the path of visitors to the site. The *nāga*'s association with abundance and the purifying nature of water must have made this an especially auspicious and noteworthy entryway.

Pitalkhora is not the only monastery to have a *nāga* gracing its entrance. Varāhadeva, the donor who built Cave 16 at Ajanta, left a lengthy inscription in which he refers to this river valley as having originally been “the abode of the *Nāga* King, its peak wreathed by masses of rain clouds” (Figure 27).²⁰ While extolling his cave's features, Varāhadeva also notes “a large cistern [filled with] copious water” and “a dwelling for the *Nāga* King.”²¹ This “dwelling” is almost certainly the large *nāga* shrine and sculpture located below Cave 16 on a path leading up from the river (Figure 28). The

Figure 28. *Nāga* sculpture below Ajanta Cave 16, Aurangabad District, India, fifth century CE. Photograph: John C. Huntington, courtesy of the Huntington Photographic Archive of Buddhist and Asian Art, 1970.

inscription ends with a poetic plea that the donor's monastic residence remain inhabited for as long as sun shines and the peak remains crowded with multitudes of clouds resembling serpent hoods.²²

The presence of these figures at Ajanta and similar sites highlights the association between *nāgas*, water regulation, and the early Buddhist monastic community. Furthermore, the monastic proximity and access to *nāgas* both implies and reinforces the idea that the *saṃgha* possess some ability to regulate *nāgas* and, by extension, rainfall. Support for this claim and further insight into this process is provided by a number of literary sources.

The fourth-century pilgrim Faxian provides an early example of ritualized monastic interaction with *nāgas*. He describes the monastery at Samkasya as housing a *nāga* who causes the "country to experience increase of rain and full water tanks, all timely and without any misfortune."²³ In gratitude for this service, the *nāga* was built a "house" in the monastery and given a daily blessing by monks, some of whom were required to feed him and eat in his residence.²⁴ There is no doubt that the *nāga* is in the service of the monastery, but it is also clear that the ritualized behavior of the monks ensured his continued compliance. In short, ritualized monastic upkeep of the *nāga*'s shrine ensured favorable rainfall in the region.

A later example is in the textual records left by the seventh-century Chinese Buddhist pilgrim Xuanzang. He relates the story of a lake-dwelling *nāga* who reforms his malicious ways after being tamed by a Buddhist king. The *nāga* fears that he will forget his promise to behave properly, stating: "*Nāgas* by nature are fierce and evil and cannot restrain themselves. It may be that hate will arise (in me) and I will forget to control it." In order to prevent this, the *nāga* instructs the human king to leave a bell at a lakeside monastery. The monks in residence were enjoined to look at the sky every day and to strike the bell whenever they saw dark clouds forming; the sound would remind the *nāga* of his promise to behave. Xuanzang, therefore, describes a *nāga*-centered practice intended to be undertaken by monks as a safeguard against potentially dangerous weather.²⁵

Xuanzang traveled in South Asia well after Buddhist rainmaking rituals had been established, and the seventh-century landscape he encountered was full of reminders related to Buddhist stories. Although not all were directly related to rainfall, many were intended restrain *nāgas*' wicked tendencies or to remind vis-

itors of the *nāgas*' allegiance to the dharma. The lingering presence of the Buddha's shadow was left for the *nāga* Gopāla, the traces of the Buddha's footprint called to mind the conversion of the *nāga* Apalāla, and the ringing of a bell or the sounding of a drum were all indications of Buddhist cooperation with potentially dangerous regional gods.²⁶ The persistence of legends linking Buddhism to *nāgas* and local landmarks helped to organize the way the Chinese pilgrim understood the world. More than just ponds and rivers, these geographic features were also signposts that allowed him access to a miraculous Buddhist past. Belief in the persistence of miraculous reminders and legendary *nāgas* into Xuanzang's own age helped to cement that continuity.

While visiting the renowned monastery of Nalanda, Xuanzang reported being told that the monastery was named for the *nāga* who resided in a nearby water tank. Although Xuanzang was skeptical of the attribution, the concept seems to have been accepted locally.²⁷ Likewise, at Lumbini, the place of the Buddha's birth, Xuanzang describes the presence of two streams, one warm and one cold, which were created by the *nāgas* Nanda and Upananda at the time of Śākyamuni's first bath.²⁸ Similarly, when visiting Bodhgaya, the place of the Buddha's enlightenment, Xuanzang identified a tank that served as the monastery's reservoir and was sacred to the *nāga* Muchalinda, who famously protected the Buddha from rain and storm with his coils and hoods.²⁹ Stories of the Buddha's life were widely known across the Buddhist world, but the landscape of his homeland made those events tangible to both residents and pilgrims. Perhaps due to the prevalence of rivers, ponds, and tanks, these tales also reinforced the association between Buddhism and the *nāgas* who resided at these sacred places.

Many of Xuanzang's stories about the Buddhist interaction with *nāgas* are retellings of tales found in older sources, ones that far predate both the pilgrim's accounts and the rainmaking rituals. Stories about either the conversion or the piety of *nāgas* are attested in earlier texts and sculpted images. For example, the story of the conversion of the *nāga* Apalāla appears in many textual sources, including the *Mūlasarvāstivāda Vinaya*, and has been depicted in sculpture dating to at least the second century CE (Figure 29).³⁰ The tale of the *nāga* Muchalinda protecting the Buddha from a fierce storm is also well attested in several early literary sources and sculptural examples created by the second century CE (Figure 30).³¹ The longevity of these

stories, preserved and retold over centuries, testifies to their importance. They are indicative of a wide range of tales in which *nāgas* are either converted to Buddhism or require no such conversion because they immediately and voluntarily recognized the virtue of the Buddha and the value of his teachings.³²

Although the majority of the *nāgas* one encounters in the Buddhist literature are predisposed to respect the Buddha, the tales of conversion have the most notable similarities to the rainmaking rituals developed in later centuries.³³ The legends of *nāgas* such as Apalāla or Gopāla naturally have their own unique elements, but the structure of such tales typically follows a pattern.³⁴ These confrontations are often triggered by some sort of water-related problem caused by a *nāga*. The crisis leads the people to seek assistance and is ultimately solved through Buddhist

intervention, to the benefit of all. The story of Apalāla is a good example.

This tale is preserved, with notable differences, in a number of sources, including the *Divyāvadāna* and the *Mūlasarvāstivāda Vinaya*.³⁵ I will recount the version told by Xuanzang, which is the most recent and also the most complete. Xuanzang states that a man named Gaṅgi used charms to restrain wicked *nāgas* in order to prevent storms and excessive rain. In gratitude, each family in the region gave him grain. After many families failed over several years to donate grain, Gaṅgi prayed that he might become a venomous *nāga* so he could take his revenge on them through wind and rain. His wish came true after his death, and, as a *nāga* named Apalāla, he let flow a white stream that poisoned the fields. The Buddha, seeing the plight of the people, took pity and resolved to help them. Noticing this decision, the gods who followed the Buddha pounded on the *nāga*'s mountain stronghold and the shock forced Apalāla to recognize the Buddha's strength. After the Buddha preached to him, Apalāla repented and took refuge in the Dharma. Soon after this conversion, Apalāla restored pure water to the village and promised to let the dangerous white water flow only once every twelve years so that he could live off the grain it gathered.³⁶

Not only does this story contrast the extortive practices of the non-Buddhist rainmaker Gaṅgi with the altruistic motives of the Buddha, it also demonstrates the effectiveness of Buddhists in working with *nāgas*.

Another example will help to demonstrate the pattern of interaction between *nāgas* and Buddhists in these tales. This story is from the circa fifth-century *Mahāvamsa* and features a Buddhist monk rather than the Buddha as the protagonist. Even though the story is preserved in a Sri Lankan source, it claims to relate a tale set far to the north.

In this narrative, a cruel *nāga* king named Aravāla caused hail to pour down on ripe crops and wash them into the sea. The monk Majjhantika arrived quickly to help the people. He got Aravāla's attention by walking on the surface of the lake where the *nāga* lived. Aravāla became furious and performed various terrifying acts: great winds blew, a cloud rained and thundered, lightning flashed, and the peaks of mountains were hurled down. The monk, through miraculous power, subdued all that terror. Demonstrating his supreme quiescence, he preached to Aravāla, who became humbled after hearing these words and subsequently was established in the Buddhist refuges and precepts.



Figure 29. The conversion of Apalāla *nāga*, Gandhara, first–third century CE. Indian Museum Kolkata, Kolkata, India. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 1997.



Figure 30. Coping stone with Śākyamuni protected by Muchalinda *nāga*, third century CE. Site Nagarjunakonda Museum, Nagarjunakonda, India. Photograph: Robert DeCaroli, 1997.

The monk admonished all the *nāgas*, saying, “Henceforth do not allow your anger to arise as before. Do not destroy crops, as living beings are desirous of happiness. Develop loving kindness toward beings, thinking ‘May human beings live in happiness.’”³⁷

As in the story of Apalāḥa, the conversion of an unstable and dangerous *nāga* restrains aspects of his unpredictable nature and makes him answerable to the Buddhist system of ethics. By calming the *nāga*, the Buddhist community also calms the weather, offering stability and predictability. Although the events may be fantastic, stories such as these reinforce the role of monks as intermediaries between the public and the capricious spirits of nature.

Given this context and history, the Buddhist rainmaking rituals discussed above appear far less unexpected and are certainly not a marginal or aberrant development within South Asian Buddhism. The appearance of apotropaic images of *nāgas* at early monastic sites created an association between the monasteries and meteorology that gained momentum over time. Even in the early narrative literature,

dangerous weather conditions are presented as the primary reason the Buddha and his disciples intervened into the affairs of *nāgas*. The continued importance of these tales is indicated by their prominence in the records of pilgrims visiting in the fourth through seventh centuries. Buddhist rainmaking rituals are therefore not a novel departure from Buddhist practice, but instead are the formalization of a long association between Buddhism and the spirits of water and rain. Rainmaking texts systematized a process of conversion, regulation, and control that can be traced over the course of centuries.

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Notes

1. Fowler, "In Search of the Dragon," 146–48. In one document from 867 CE the Buddhist monastery is officially named Ryūō-ji ("Temple of the Dragon King").
2. Gergley Hidas, presentation and personal discussion at SOAS, University of London, January 2017. This was an early presentation of a forthcoming translation project.
3. For the date of the text, see Bendall, "Megha-Sūtra," 286. See also Davidson, "Studies in Dhāraṇī Literature IV," 158.
4. Bendall, "Megha-Sūtra," 293–95.
5. Davidson, "Nāga Altar," 123–70.
6. Schmithausen, *Maitri and Magic*, 57.
7. For the *nāga* references, see Hidas, *Mahāmāyūri Vidyārājñī*, 224. He dates the text to the second half of the first millennium and notes the text's rising prominence in the eighth through the tenth century.
8. For a discussion of monastery placement, see Schopen, "Buddhist 'Monastery' and the Indian Garden," 224–50.
9. For a recent discussion of rock-cut cave inscriptions, particularly as they apply to unfinished caves, see Dehejia and Rockwell, *Unfinished*, 84–87.
10. My thanks to Shrikant Ganvir and his colleagues at Deccan College, Pune, for generously obtaining this photo for me.
11. Shaw, "Archaeologies of Buddhist Propagation in Ancient India," 84–91; and Shaw, "Nāga Sculptures in Sanchi's Archaeological Landscape," 5–8. She links this practice to the growing influence of Buddhism in the region.
12. DeCaroli, *Haunting the Buddha*, 83–84. The translation of Tog Ta 335b.6–337b.2 was kindly provided by Gregory Schopen in a personal correspondence.
13. Lüders, *Mathurā*, 148–49; and Härtel, "Aspects of the Early Nāga Cult," 670.
14. Lüders, *Mathurā*, 173–74.
15. Lüders, "List of Brahmi Inscriptions," 136, no. 1186.
16. Härtel, "Aspects of the Early Nāga Cult," 669; and Bühler, "New Kharoṣṭhi Inscription," 141–42.
17. The current tank and sculpture date to renovations conducted by King Aggabodhi I in the late sixth and early seventh centuries. There is some uncertainty about whether the ancient (ca. first century CE) name of the pool was Nāgacatukka, Nāgasonḍi, or both. Those early names are recorded in the *Māhavaṃsa* and *Dīpavaṃsa*. See, for example, *Māhavaṃsa*, xiv, 36.
18. Most *yantragalas* have not been recovered intact, but examples from the 1946 excavation of an image house in Medirigiriya were found with the ritual deposits in place. Among the materials contained were the sculptures of four ani-

mals (associated with the cardinal directions) and the images of the deities Kuvera and Vajrapāni, but no *nāga* was among them.

19. Kulatunga, *Abhayagiri Vihara*, 44–45.
20. Cohen, *Setting the Three Jewels*, 357–62.
21. Ibid., 362.
22. Ibid.
23. See Davidson, "Nāga Altar," 159–60; and Fa-Hien, *Record of Buddhistic Kingdoms*, 51–52.
24. Davidson, "Nāga Altar," 159–60; and Fa-Hien, *Record of Buddhistic Kingdoms*, 51–52.
25. Deeg, *Miscellanae Nepalicae*, 73–76; and Hiuen Tsiang, *Si-Yu-Ki*, 1:63–66.
26. For the story of Gopāla, see Hiuen Tsiang, *Si-Yu-Ki*, 1:94. Some version this story was apparently known even in the time of Faxian (fourth century) since he mentions that three of his companions made the journey to see the miraculous shadow. Fa-Hien, *Record of Buddhistic Kingdoms*, 36. For the story of Apālāla, see Hiuen Tsiang, *Si-Yu-Ki*, 1:123; and Huili, *Great Tang Dynasty Records*, 84–85. For drum or bells, see Hiuen Tsiang, *Si-Yu-Ki*, 1:63–66, 2:320. For a discussion of early sources for the tale of Gopāla, see Deeg, *Miscellanae Nepalicae*, 102–4.
27. Hiuen Tsiang, *Si-Yu-Ki*, 2:167; and Huili, *Great Tang Dynasty Records*, 281.
28. Hiuen Tsiang, *Si-Yu-Ki*, 2:24–25; and Huili, *Great Tang Dynasty Records*, 179–80.
29. Hiuen Tsiang, *Si-Yu-Ki*, 2:128; and Huili, *Great Tang Dynasty Records*, 254. There was a small shrine to the Buddha at the edge of the pool.
30. Ch'en, "Study of the Svāgata Story," 238, 279–80.
31. For an early account, see Davids and Oldenberg, *Vinaya Texts*, pt. 1, 80–81; for a full discussion of the sources, see Nakamura, *Gotama Buddha*, 221–22. Visual references to this tale may date to before the first century CE if images of coiled *nāgas*, of the sort found on drum slabs at Amaravati, are aniconic representations of this event.
32. Vogel, *Indian Serpent Lore*, 93–154; and Deeg, *Miscellanae Nepalicae*, 97–100. See also DeCaroli, "Abode of a Nāga King," 142–61.
33. Examples include Muchalinda, Kālīka, Nanda, Upananda, Kṛṣṇa, and Gautamaka. For the references, see Vogel, *Indian Serpent Lore*, 95–97, 98–105, 115–18.
34. Hiuen Tsiang, *Si-Yu-Ki*, 1:94, 123; and Huili, *Great Tang Dynasty Records*, 84–85.
35. Vogel, *Indian Serpent Lore*, 121n1. See also Cowell and Neil, *Divyāvadāna*, 384–85, 348–49. See also Przyluski, "Le nord-ouest de l'Inde dans le vinaya," 510–12.
36. Hiuen Tsiang, *Si-Yu-Ki*, 1:123; and Huili, *Great Tang Dynasty Records*, 85.
37. *Māhavaṃsa*, xii, 9–21. For a discussion of this legend and its various versions, see Deeg, *Miscellanae Nepalicae*, 145–52.

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